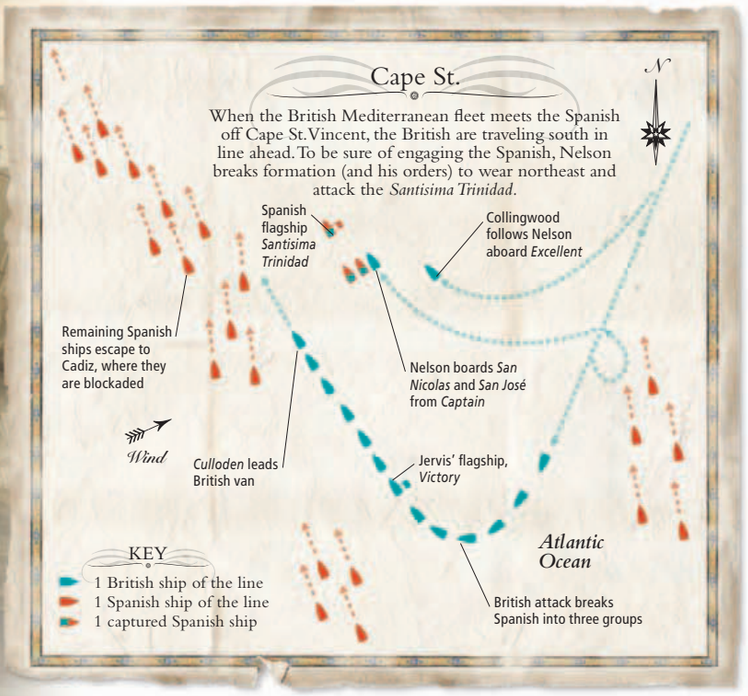




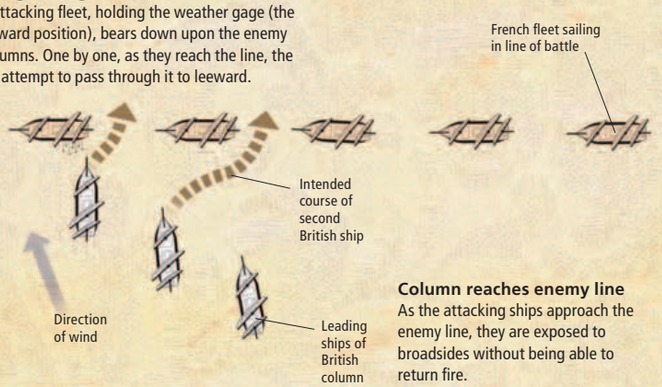
MAN-OF-WAR TACTICS

BREAKING THE LINE

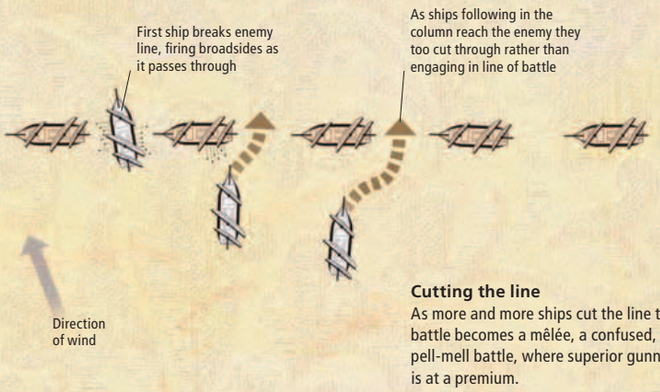
TACTICS IN THE AGE OF NELSON

The line of battle used by fleets in combat from the 17th century was intended to ensure that each ship came alongside an enemy for a broadside duel. By the late 18th century many British naval commanders had become convinced that breaking the enemy line offered better opportunities for a decisive victory. First used by Admiral George Rodney at the Saints in 1782, breaking the line was brought to perfection by Admiral Nelson at the battle of Trafalgar and Duncan at Camperdown. Although this tactic exposed the attacking ships to fire they could not return during the approach, they could rake enemy vessels from stem to stern as they passed through and also prevent enemy ships withdrawing by engaging them from the leeward side. The attacking fleet would hope to outnumber the ships in the sections of the enemy line that they attacked, while the rest of the enemy ships were left out of the fight. Nelson favored breaking the line above all as a way of precipitating a "pell-mell" battle in which captains could use individual initiative to take on and destroy their opponents.

Cutting through the line
The attacking fleet, holding the weather gage (the windward position), bears down upon the enemy in columns. One by one, as they reach the line, the ships attempt to pass through it to leeward.



Column reaches enemy line
As the attacking ships approach the enemy line, they are exposed to broadsides without being able to return fire.



Cutting the line
As more and more ships cut the line the battle becomes a mêlée, a confused, pell-mell battle, where superior gunnery is at a premium.

Raking fire
As a ship cuts through the enemy line, it can unleash a broadside in either direction, while the enemy is unable to return fire. Raking fire sent shot and splinters through the entire length of a ship's decks, causing maximum casualties to the crew.

